that aim to empower women and provide financial assistance to students from historically disadvantaged groups.

Going a step further than his father, Jagan has also ensured the political empowerment of OBCs. His government has nominated four OBC members to the Rajya Sabha and 18 to the legislative council. Eleven OBC legislators have been made ministers and they along with SC, ST and minority members account for 70 per cent of Jagan's cabinet. At the grassroots level, where the YSRC controls 635 of the 648 local bodies, 239 posts of mandal praja parishad president have been given to OBCs—38 per cent of the total.

That said, this welfare-focused approach comes with its own set of challenges. The opposition, including the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), has been trying to corner Jagan by demanding a white paper on the state's finances given the mounting debt. Winning over the OBCs becomes even more important given the high stakes, as Jagan has to not only beat anti-incumbency but, in all likelihood, do so while taking on a united Opposition if he wants to come close to his ambitious target of winning all 175 assembly seats in 2024.

The TDP is already trying to get back its core voters, especially the OBCs, and has the potential to win over other social groups not happy with Jagan, says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. "If Naidu's TDP enters into a pre-poll alliance with actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP), which is quite likely, then it will not be an easy election to win for Jagan," adds G. Kiran Kumar, national president, All India OBC Students Association.

Meanwhile, the BJP is also trying hard to woo the OBCs with an eye on the Lok Sabha election, and has deployed their national general secretary Satya Kumar to work out the strategy. The challenge for Jagan will only multiply if the BJP joins hands with the possible TDP-JSP combine. Against this backdrop, he is appointing regional coordinators in each district and an observer for each assembly segment to address rifts within the party. With multiple variables at play, Jagan knows he cannot afford any miscalculation at this stage. ■



MOHAMMAD ALEEMUDDIN

TROUBLESHOOTER
Digvijay Singh at a presser in Hyderabad

TELANGANA/ CONGRESS

EXISTENTIAL CRISIS

By Amarnath K. Menon

For veteran Congress leader Digvijay Singh, essaying the role of a troubleshooter comes with effortless ease. So, as the Congress stares at a political crisis in Telangana, the party bosses dispatched him to defuse the infighting that is fast transforming into an unseemly 'native-versus-migrant' conflict.

On gauging that an amicable solution was unreachable, Singh spent an entire day (December 22) meeting party heavyweights and other leaders one by one—only to announce in the end that Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) president A. Revanth Reddy will lead the party into the 2023 assembly election and present a report to the party high command on how to dissolve the sharpening divide.

Some of the leaders are learnt to be furious over a social media campaign being run against them, allegedly at Revanth Reddy's behest. The crisis deepened after a group of dissident leaders held a meeting on December 17 and voiced their objection to the packing of party panels with turncoats from other parties. The TPCC chief himself joined the Congress after resigning from the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in 2017.

Such is the acrimony that several senior Congress leaders say replacing Revanth Reddy is the only way the Grand Old Party will have any chance of wresting power from the Bharatiya Rashtra Samithi (BRS). Moreover, the Congress cadre's morale is at an all-time low since the debacle in the assembly bypoll for the Munugode seat, which was forced by the resignation of sitting party MLA K. Raj Gopal Reddy, who